

ern army commander. Poor equipment and training means ten army soldiers do the job that can be done by three. "The Shamshabari range in J&K can be covered by a single ambush of troops equipped with hands-free radios and night vision devices. My troops lack sufficient night vision devices (NVD) hence I have to set up three ambushes," the officer says.

"Yes equipment is essential but the army has been fighting counter-insurgency for 20 years despite the lack of equipment," says a senior army official. His confidence comes

equipped with lightweight disposable anti-tank rockets and anti-material rifles (AMR)—a heavy rifle which fires high caliber rounds to destroy vehicles and light fortifications. Kargil was the first wake-up call for the infantry, leading to a massive shake up of the procurement process. The army acquired Battlefield Surveillance Systems, night vision devices, handheld thermal imagers, AMRs and automatic grenade launchers in the first major infantry modernisation since the 1962 war. Ambitious plans were drawn up for

limitations of the system. Last year, the army was stumped when the OFB said it could deliver only 50,000 new-generation grenades per year instead of a requirement of 10 lakh. "At this rate of production, it will take us decades to replace the 36-M," says an exasperated general.

In other cases, radical indigenous solutions have been torpedoed for no apparent reason. In 2008, the army pulled the plug on the Sathi or the Situation Awareness and Tactical Handheld Information, billed as the world's first hand-held battle com-



AN INFANTRY MAN WITH AN IMPROVED RIFLE ATTACHMENT

AP PHOTO

Delayed Vehicles

The infantry lack specialised mobility and protection

225 MINE PROTECTED VEHICLES (MPV)

DATE: FIRST ORDERED FROM OFB IN 2005

STATUS: Delivery delayed by 28 months

64 SNOW SCOOTERS

DATE: OLD SCOOTERS NEED REPLACEMENT SINCE 2000

STATUS: Defence Ministry wants a fresh tender



"THE INDIAN INFANTRY-MAN IS POORLY TRAINED

AND EQUIPPED. HIGH ON BRAVADO AND LOW ON EQUIPMENT AND TRAINING. I WOULD RATE HIM 3/10."

LT-GEN. (retd) H. S. PANAG



puter, which would give the infantry soldier essential requirements like GPS coordinates and digital maps. The army said the item could be purchased off the shelf. Needless to say, no hand-held battle computer has been

from the fact that the 1.1-million-strong army has managed to contain insurgency in Kashmir and has begun thinning men now. But their success is largely due to the fact that the army has poured men into the breach without feeling the pinch of equipment. But in a conventional war like the one in Kargil in 1999, such flaws are instantly exposed. Officers recount how they stormed Pakistani bunkers and found the enemy

the Future Infantry Soldier As System project (F-INSAS) or a futuristic warrior equipped with GPS, night scopes, wearable computers and lightweight body armour. A decade later, with a dangerous slump hitting the system, the prototype of the F-INSAS project was to have been fielded by 2012 but may materialise only around 2017.

When approval for a weapon system does indeed come through, its replacement runs up against the

acquired till now and the soldier still relies on maps that were first drawn in the 19th century.

The snow scooters the Indian Army uses in Siachen and for which then defence minister George Fernandes famously dispatched bureaucrats who held up their acquisition to the front, have reached the end of their useful lives and need to be replaced. The original equipment manufacturer has stopped making